



University Corridors for Refugees (UNICORE)

Report 2019-2024

Background¹

In the November 2016 New York Declaration on Refugees and Migrants (New York Declaration), States Parties committed to expanding opportunities for refugees and persons in need of international protection to enter a third country through safe and legal channels of entry, adhering to resettlement programs and promoting **complementary pathways to entry and protection**.

The New York Declaration further articulates the commitment to develop humanitarian pathways and increase opportunities for refugees to obtain **study visas** or access **scholarships** in European Union member states.

On Dec. 17, 2018, the United Nations General Assembly approved Global Compact on Refugees after two years of extensive consultations conducted by UNHCR with member states, international organizations, refugees, civil society, the private sector and experts. One of the Compact's four macro goals is precisely to **expand access to solutions in third countries by developing new pathways or strengthening existing ones**.

UNHCR provided operational and guiding lines with its **Three-Year Strategy (2019-2021) on**

¹ Reference sources:

-New York Declaration on Refugees and Migrants, 2016

<https://refugeesmigrants.un.org/declaration>;

-Global Refugee Pact, 2018, <https://refugeesmigrants.un.org/refugees-compact>;

Education 2030: A Strategy for Refugee Education - UNHCR, 2019,

<https://www.unhcr.org/publications/education/5d651da88d7/education-2030-strategy-refugee-education.html>;

-Three-Year Strategy (2019-2021) on Resettlement and Complementary Pathways, 2019,

<https://www.unhcr.org/5d15db254.pdf>



Resettlement and Complementary Pathways in which it clarified how to develop sustainable growth pathways, engaging new stakeholders and creating welcoming and inclusive societies.

UNHCR's operational engagement in the implementation of legal and safe channels of entry for refugees is part of its broader protection work aimed at identifying durable solutions for refugees, working with states to this end.

Quality higher education plays a key role in helping young refugees equip themselves with the tools to become self-sufficient and build a future in line with their aspirations. It can have a tangible impact and positively influence individuals' entire lives by enabling them to become an important resource for their families, host-country communities, and – potentially - to contribute to post-conflict reconstruction in their home countries.

According to data from the latest UNHCR report, only 7% of refugees globally have access to higher education.

UNHCR aims to achieve a **15% enrollment rate² in tertiary education programs** for refugees in host and third countries by 2030, including through the expansion of safe entry pathways that take into account their needs and aspirations, and **to admit more than 2,000,000 refugees to third countries by 2028³** through complementary entry pathways in order to share the responsibility of low- and middle-income countries that currently host 69 percent of the refugee population globally⁴.

² 15by30 Roadmap <https://www.unhcr.org/605a0fb3b.pdf>

³ Third Country Solutions for Refugees: Roadmap 2030, <https://globalcompactrefugees.org/sites/default/files/2022-08/Third%20Country%20Solutions%20for%20Refugees%20-%20Roadmap%202030.pdf>

⁴ -MID-YEAR TRENDS 2024 <https://www.unhcr.org/mid-year-trends-report-2024>



Project Description

The university corridors project ([University Corridors for Refugees, UNICORE](#)) aims to promote and increase opportunities for refugee students - present in countries of first asylum - to obtain **study visas and access scholarships in Italy** through *ad hoc* opportunities offered by universities and/or higher education organizations and thus be able to complete their studies.

The objective is to create and consolidate a **safe and regular entry model specifically for refugees**, recognized as such in specific countries of first asylum, already in possession of a bachelor's degree, who intend to pursue a university degree (master's degree) in Italy.

The ultimate goal, however, is not only to guarantee entry into Italy and provide a scholarship and other primary services (food, lodging, etc.), but **to accompany them on their path of study and social inclusion in Italy, in order to contribute to the consolidation of inclusive and welcoming societies.**

The project began with a pilot phase in 2019 when 6 students, recognized refugees in Ethiopia, were selected to receive a scholarship from the University of Bologna and LUISS University of Rome.

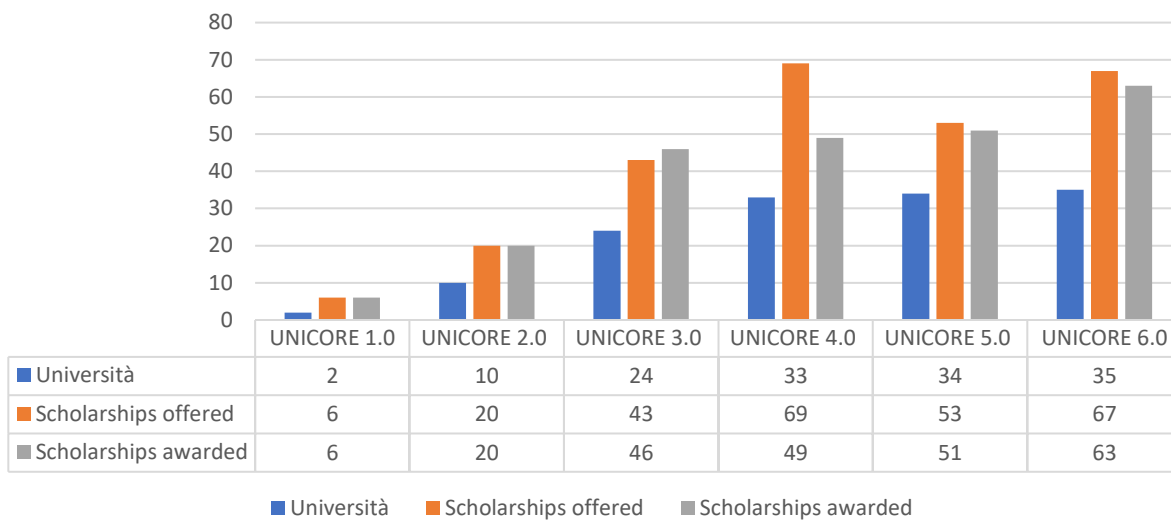
Building on this success, in 2020 10 universities offered 20 scholarships, while in 2021 the number of participating universities increased to 24 with an actual offer of 43 scholarships.

For the latest ongoing edition, UNICORE 6.0, 35 universities have joined the project by providing 67 scholarships.

In six years, 42 universities have offered 258 study opportunities to refugee students abroad.

At the same time, the number of asylum countries involved has also increased, including Kenya, Mozambique, Niger, Nigeria, South Africa, Tanzania, Uganda, Zambia and Zimbabwe for the sixth

UNICORE 2019-2024_ Universities and scholarships.



edition of the project.⁵

Beneficiaries of the project are students, recognized refugees in the identified countries of asylum, who have completed the first three-year cycle of academic studies - within the five years prior to the closing of the UNICORE calls - with a score of 3.0 or higher GPA (*Grade Point Average*) and who are highly motivated to continue their studies in Italy.

At the local level, the project is supported by the Diocesan Caritas, the territorial branches of the Waldensian Diaconia, the Centro Astalli for Refugees and by associations and entities of various nature⁶, which sign territorial partnership protocols where burdens and tasks are divided to facilitate the inclusion path of the beneficiaries.

The project is implemented with a strong participatory component of the refugees, universities

⁵ Ethiopia for the first three editions of UNICORE and Cameroon, Malawi, Mozambique, Niger, Nigeria, South Africa, Zambia and Zimbabwe for UNICORE 4.0, and Kenya, Niger, Nigeria, South Africa, Uganda, Zambia and Zimbabwe for UNICORE 5.0.

⁶ <https://universitycorridors.unhcr.it/local-partners/>



and partners involved, thanks *inter alia* to the *thematic focus groups* organized periodically with selected groups of students. Surveys and polls cyclically administered, processed and shared through dedicated meetings ensure that all stakeholders have the opportunity to actively contribute to the improvement of the project.

Finally, based on needs that emerged upon completion of the course of study (such as students' need for support to enter the labor market) the UNICORE national working table focused on making the exit transition from the project as smooth as possible. In particular, training, internship and employment opportunities are shared periodically with students through the support network present at the national and local levels, and initiatives are promoted *as available* at the national level.

In 2024, for the first time, UNHCR and partners held online meetings between UNICORE students and external parties. Examples include a training session with LinkedIn to improve students' profiles on the platform making the job search more effective, meetings with Manpower through its Young Talent in Action program to support access to the labor market, and two meetings with the Adecco Foundation, UNHCR's partner in the *Welcome. Working for refugee integration* program, to present UNICORE students with the Welcome In-one-click platform aimed at facilitating the connection between companies, refugees and the third sector for pathways to job inclusion that take into account the characteristics, skills and ambitions of refugee people. Finally, since the last edition, Permira staff has been conducting mentoring activities to some of the students present in Milan.

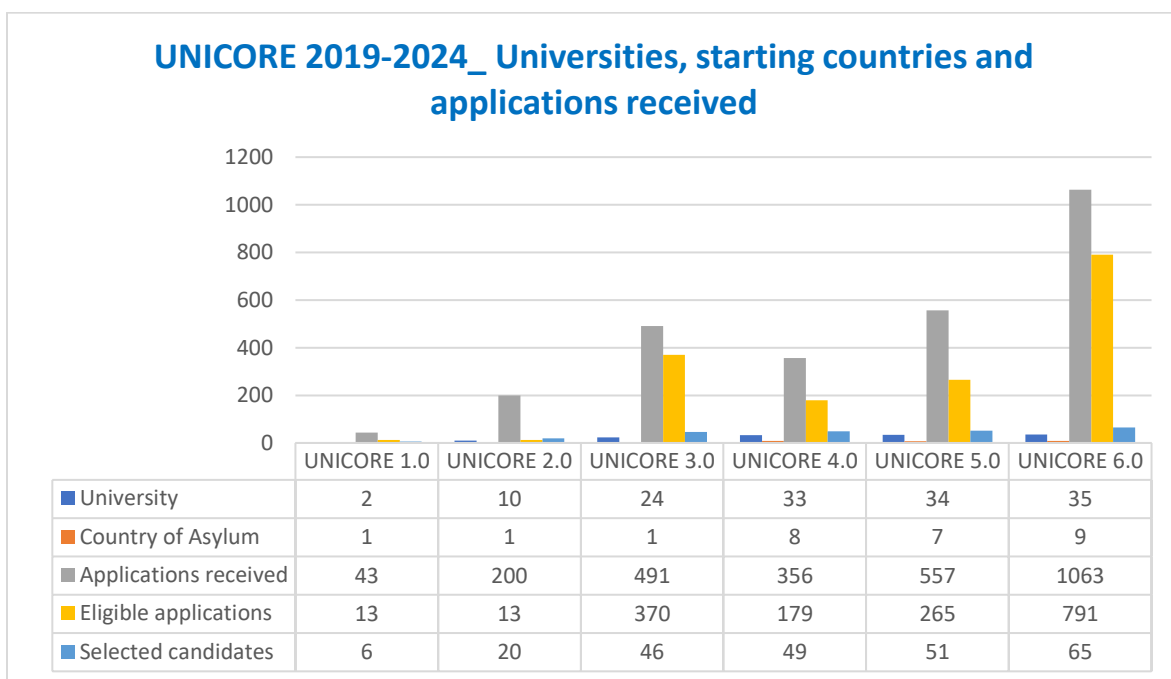
Statistical data 2019-2024

Beyond the figures linked to participation in the program, universities⁷ observed a steady

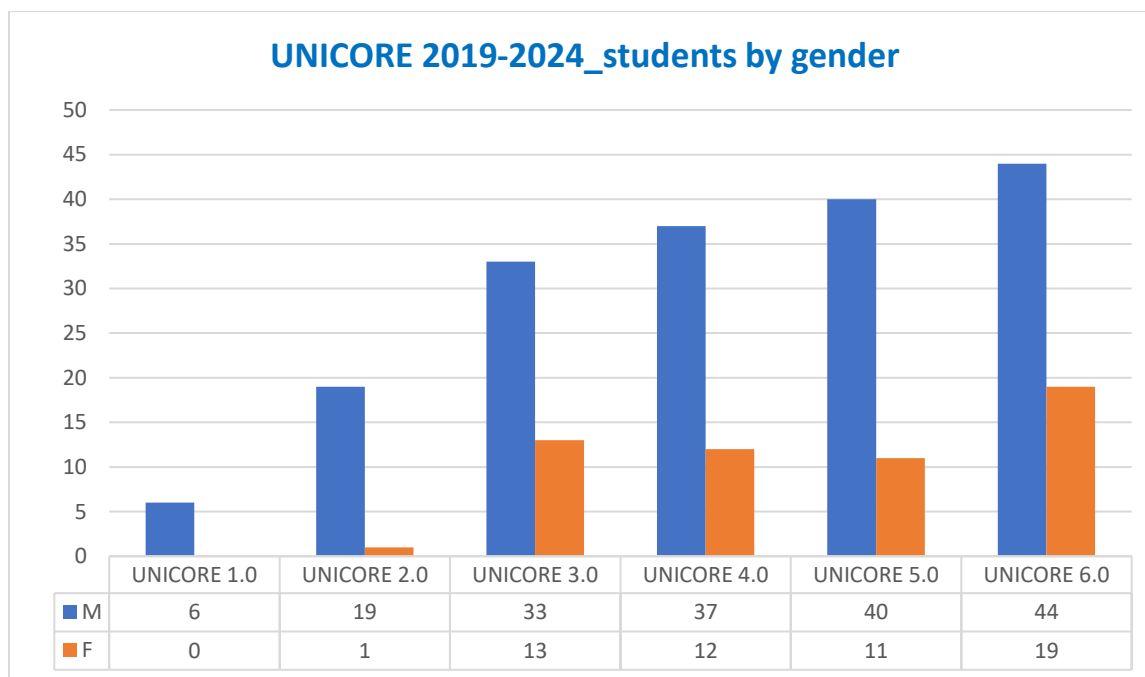
⁷ As of UNICORE 4.0 new first-asylum countries were included, see note above, and there was thus a slight decrease in applications received due to the timing of new project start-up in the fourth edition, then largely recovered particularly during the sixth edition.

increase in the number of applications received over the six editions of UNICORE. There was also an increase in the number of eligible applications submitted and of students selected.

Under UNICORE 6.0, the number of applications received doubled compared to the previous edition, partly due to the updated and centralized system for submitting and sorting applications.



At present, most project beneficiaries are men, while women make up 24 percent of the total.



Over the years, some universities have taken actions aimed at increasing the possibility for female students to access the program, such as providing separate rankings. For UNICORE 6.0, the highest percentage of female refugees was recorded among selected students (31%); however, further efforts remain needed for future years, such as allowing flexible criteria for female applicants (e.g., GPA at 2.5).

Regarding the first five editions of UNICORE, 61% of the students who arrived in the first 3 years graduated as expected, while most of the beneficiaries are currently pursuing their studies at the destination universities (99 subjects).

At present⁸, **62 students have graduated (most of them, on time)** and among them, by way of example, **21 have obtained employment contracts**, 12 of them dealing with activities related to the course of study, **4 are doing a training internship**, and **8 have received an additional grant**

⁸ April 2025.



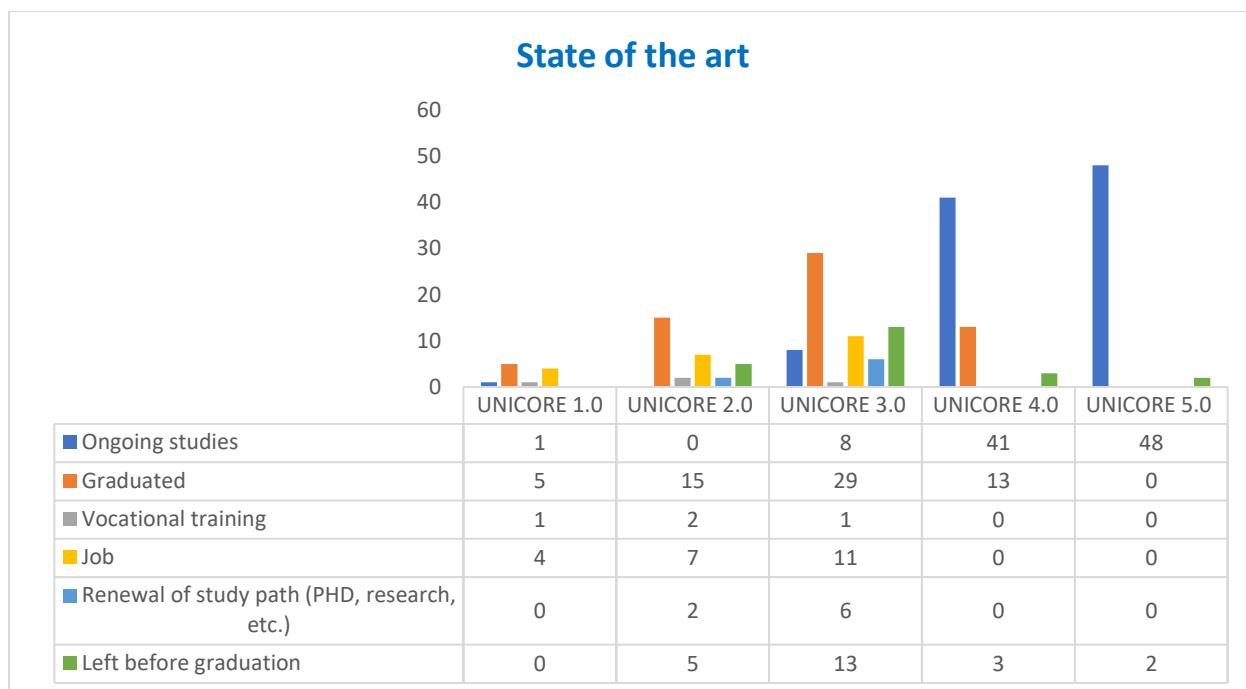
to continue their studies through a PhD or the award of a research contract.

Post-graduate paths taken in Italy and abroad include, among UNICORE recipients who went on to further their studies, a PhD at the University of Parma and one at the University of Bergamo; three research contracts including one at the National Research Council (CNR) in Pisa, one at Vanvitelli University and one at the Technical University of Chemnitz in Germany.

Regarding internships and work contracts we mention internships at the Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO) in Rome; at the European University Institute - Florence School of Transnational Governance, and at the Embassy of Canada in Rome; an open-ended and a fixed-term contract with Banca Ifis; the employment with a hospitality cooperative in Florence; the employment as a receptionist at the Valdese Guesthouse in Florence; and area coordination at Relief International (RI) in South Sudan.

As for the remaining graduate students, the partners are collecting and updating information about them, thanks to the accompanying support provided where necessary.

During their time in Italy, some UNICORE students had the opportunity to actively participate in prestigious international initiatives and *fora*, including the *High Commissioner's Dialogue on Protection Challenges* (2022) and the Global Refugee Forum (2023), both held in Geneva; a conference on *Equipping Student Leaders as Partners for Sustainable Humanitarian Action* organized by International Students Overcoming War (ISOW) in Waterloo (Canada); meetings organized under the AMIF EU-PASSWORLD Project in Venice, Bologna, Lisbon and Leuven (2022-2024).



Finally, 23 beneficiaries left the program before graduation, particularly during the third edition of UNICORE (13 subjects). The causes of the dropouts are still being investigated, and the universities, in coordination with UNHCR and partners, have taken the necessary steps to try to track the students, report them missing, and prevent similar incidents in the future. As part of the project, a distinction was made between those who dropped out shortly after arriving in Italy (a few days to a few weeks), from those who left more than a year after arriving in Italy or in any case before graduation.

The first phenomenon, which affected almost exclusively the third edition, led to the adoption of measures, first and foremost the improvement of the selection process with techniques aimed at assessing the students' motivation, which almost completely eliminated this phenomenon. The second phenomenon affected about 10 students out of the 235 who arrived in Italy and relates to difficulties in continuing their studies or finding a job deemed suitable and appears, in

percentage terms, to be lower than the average found in Italy (4.2% against a national average of 7.3%⁹).

With reference to the legal status of admitted students, the 6 students in the UNICORE 1.0 edition applied for international protection in Italy after graduation or at least about 3 years after entering Italy. All of them obtained some form of international protection.

With respect to the 15 students who remained in the project in the second edition, 4 applied for asylum upon the second expiration of their residence permit and were granted a form of international protection, 2 were granted residence permits for work purposes, and the other 9 renewed their residence permits for study purposes. We specify that one student returned to Ethiopia after graduation, while 6 moved to other countries, including UK, Denmark, Norway, and North Macedonia.

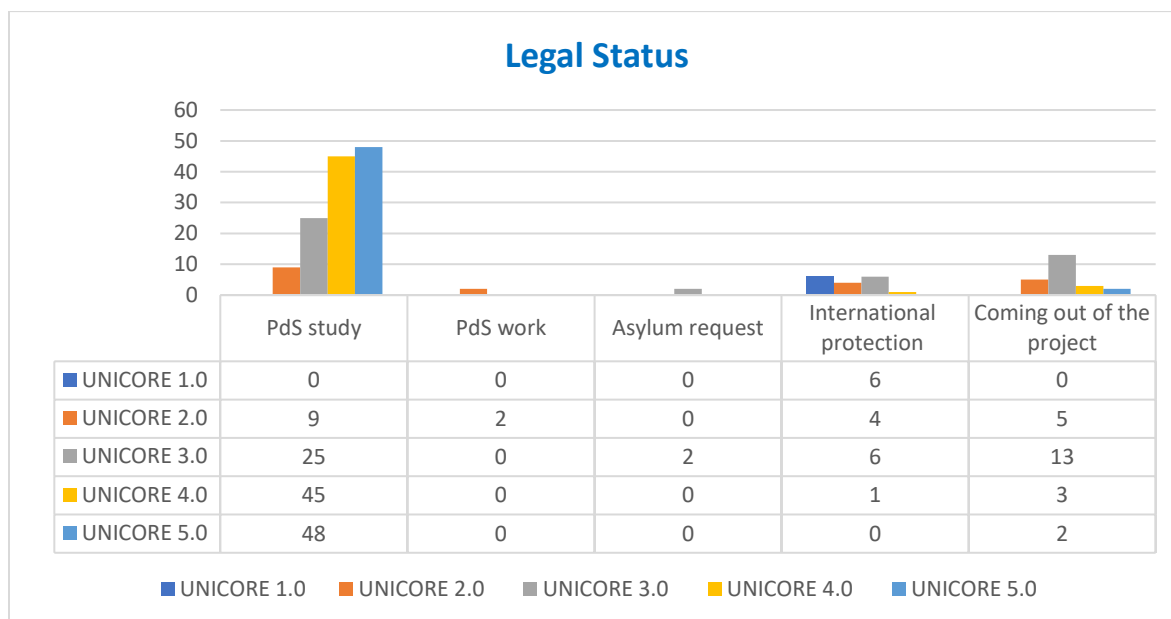
The 33 students who remained in the third edition project mostly hold study permits (25), 8 of them have applied for asylum and have been granted some form of international protection (6), while 2 are awaiting a decision on their protection application. It is clarified that two students have returned to Ethiopia after graduation, while 11 have moved to other countries, including Australia, Canada, France, Germany, North Macedonia, the Netherlands, Sweden and the USA.

The 46 students remaining in the fourth edition project almost all hold study permits (45), while one applied for and obtained a form of international protection. One student in this edition moved to Belgium for family and health reasons, currently exceptionally managing to proceed with her studies from that country.

Finally, of the 48 students remaining in UNICORE 5.0, all of them hold study permits.

The data is, however, undergoing continuous processing by the partners who are collecting and updating the relevant information, thanks to the support provided where necessary.

⁹ <https://www.ilsole24ore.com/art/mai-cosi-tanti-abbandoni-all-universita-73percento-lascia-AEy54iWD>



Procedure

The project consists of the following phases, which generally start towards the end of the year¹⁰ and conclude with the arrival of students in September/October¹¹ of the following year for the start of academic courses.

1. PROGRAM DESIGN (October/November – February/March)

- Identification of UNHCR operations abroad and countries of asylum based on specific criteria related to the refugee population, presence of Italian embassy there, available documents, etc.
- Identifying national and local universities and partners
- Preparation and finalization of the national protocol
- Preparation and finalization of university calls

¹⁰ The exact dates for each edition are agreed upon with the universities participating in each edition.

¹¹ For the current edition, there were some delays that significantly delayed the arrival of students until January.

- Dissemination in countries of asylum

- Creation of local partnerships

2. SELECTION (March/April – June)

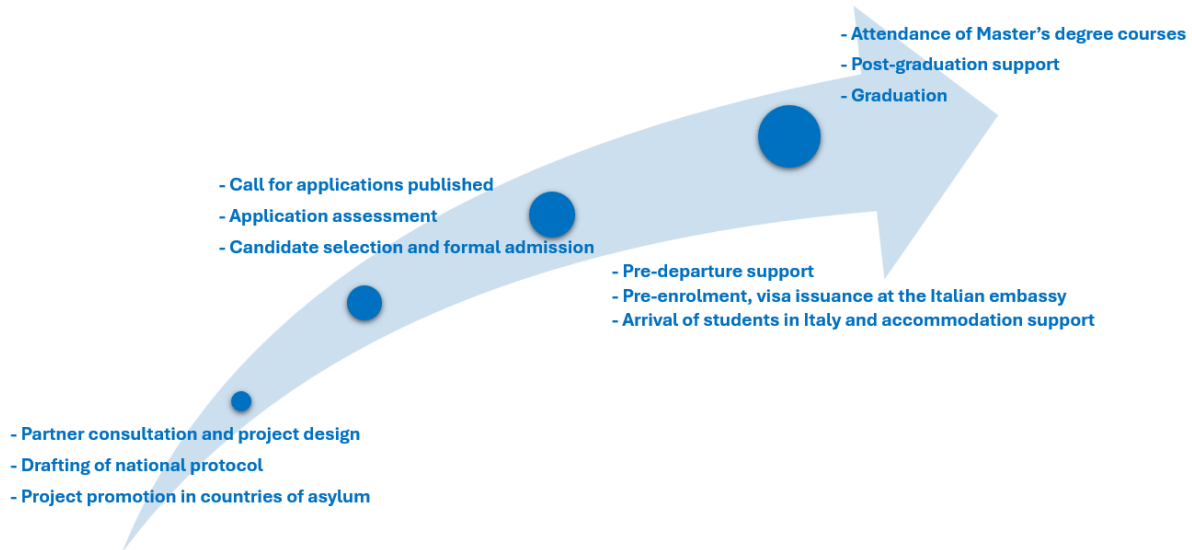
- Publication of UNICORE calls
- Eligibility screening and short-listing
- Interviews and selection
- Publication of winners
- Preparation and finalization of local protocols

3. PRE-DEPARTURE ACTIVITIES (July-September/October)

- Initiation of pre-enrollment procedures on the UniversItaly platform
- Application for travel documents and visa
- Online Italian language courses
- Pre-departure briefings
- Online meeting between student/university/local partnership
- Departure

4. TRAVEL AND STUDY INITIATION/CONCLUSION (September/October and in the following 2/3 years)

- Arrival and reception
- Finalization of university enrollment
- Application for residence permit/tax ID/ enrolment in the Italian National Health System (SSN) or health insurance policy/opening of bank account, etc.
- Beginning of study courses and start of the inclusion pathway



Involved subjects

In addition to the participating universities and UNHCR, national partners of the UNICORE project are the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and International Cooperation, Caritas Italiana, Diaconia Valdese, Centro Astalli per Rifugiati (Italian branch of *Jesuit Refugee Service - JRS*) and *Gandhi Charity*.

As of 2022, Banca Etica¹² has signed an agreement to provide support to students admitted to the program both by facilitating the opening of bank accounts and by offering scholarships or training internships, to be activated during the undergraduate or postgraduate period.

ACRI, Association of Italian Savings Banks, co-financed the project in the 3.0, 4.0 and 5.0 editions, contributing to the purchase of airline tickets, integration activities and health support. While donations received from Calzedonia, Dieci Trust Onlus and Permira supported the

¹² <https://globalcompactrefugees.org/good-practices/financial-services-framework-unicore-university-corridors-refugees>



implementation of the project in the fifth and sixth editions.

Alongside national partners, each university identifies local partners called upon to offer specific student support services.

National and local partners (which include municipalities, NGOs, voluntary associations, banking foundations, etc.) then offer each student a range of services and benefits that aim not only to ensure their entry into the territory but also a positive and gradual path to inclusion in Italy.

A rewarding feature of the project is the centrality of the participating universities, which are charged not only with preparing an ad hoc call for applications but also have sole responsibility for the selection of applicants based on the academic skills acquired in their previous course of study and of their motivation. Moreover, the universities are required to closely follow and monitor, together with local partners, the students' course of study and inclusion through periodic meetings to intervene, if necessary, with any corrective measures or more specific support actions.

The project has been further enriched from year to year based on *lessons learned* from previous editions. For example, given the difficulty of students who have arrived in Italy in learning the Italian language (also due to the fact that the vast majority of university courses are exclusively in English), starting with the third edition, online Italian language courses - in the pre-departure phase - have been provided for the selected students, made available free of charge by the University for Foreigners of Siena and Perugia in recent years (and by the University of Notre Dame for the fourth and fifth editions). It is intended to further enhance language learning by encouraging participation in Italian courses on the ground.

On a regular basis, the national partners organize coordination meetings to get a timely picture of the progress of the project, the needs related to the territories and specifically the needs of individual students, with the goal of following and monitoring their path to graduation and subsequent post-graduation opportunities (stay in Italy with asylum application or renewal/conversion of residence permit for study/work; return to the country of first asylum).



In recent months, also close to the conclusion of the course of study and the insertion into the world of work, interlocutions have been initiated with specific realities in which graduate students are carrying out professional experiences to date, such as Banca IFIS, the Canadian Embassy in Rome and the *International Institute of Humanitarian Law* in Sanremo.

For the UNICORE 6.0 edition, a new strategic partner was the nonprofit organization Miles4Migrants, which works globally to provide flights to forcibly displaced people in need, specifically using miles donated by private individuals. Miles4Migrants provided its technical and practical support in booking the winning students' airline flights at an extremely advantageous cost - consisting only of taxes and management costs - which resulted in significant savings (over 60 percent) for the partners committed to paying for the winning students' air transportation and the eight universities that funded their students' flights. This allowed the remaining funds to be used otherwise within the project itself. To contribute to the activities carried out by Miles4Migrants under the UNICORE project, a dedicated web page was created.¹³

Finally, since the sixth edition, the Experience Foundation has offered free accommodation within the Campus x structure in Milan to some of the second-year students.

Communication

The UNICORE project was also very successful at the media level.

From April 2020 to date, UNICORE has been mentioned just over **900** times **in the Italian media**, including radio and television, print and online media, making it one of the most mentioned projects among those implemented by UNHCR.

UNICORE has been the subject of about **28 interviews/stories**, including international newspapers, and RAI TV programs aired abroad, such as RAI Italia. Some of the students' stories

¹³ https://miles4migrants.org/unicore_it/



became video content spread on various social channels such as YouTube, Facebook and Instagram.

Finally, the project's website, universitycorridors.unhcr.co.uk, has had **257,704 page views** from April 2020 to date.

Final considerations

The UNICORE project constitutes a particularly innovative experience in the Italian and European landscape. Its strengths include synergy between institutional and non-institutional actors, coordination at the central and local levels, and the involvement of different actors. UNICORE represents a model to which other European countries are looking at such as Belgium and Ireland within the project "*EU-Passworld: widening complementary pathways linked to Community Sponsorship*" financed by the European Commission with AMIF funds and aimed *inter alia* at the expansion of university corridors in Belgium and Ireland. It should also be noted that France has launched Corridors UNIV'R University for Refugees¹⁴ and that in the Netherlands preliminary actions are being taken to create Education Pathways on the UNICORE model.

Moreover, UNICORE was presented by the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and International Cooperation as Italian *best practice* at the *Global Refugee Forum* in December 2019¹⁵ and again by the University of Bologna, as the spokesperson for the other universities involved, at the second edition in 2023¹⁶. In addition, the program has been the subject of extensive study and analysis, so much so that to date 5 theses have been dedicated to it, as well as having been presented at numerous Italian and international fora.

¹⁴ <https://help.unhcr.org/kenya/wp-content/uploads/sites/29/2022/03/211012-UNIVR-project-summary.pdf>

¹⁵ <https://globalcompactrefugees.org/gcr-action/countries/italy>

¹⁶ <https://globalcompactrefugees.org/good-practices/unicore>



Six years after its launch, UNHCR, Caritas Italiana, and Diaconia Valdese are working to improve some of the critical issues that emerged during the various project phases, the most relevant of which are indicated below.

The areas on which action is considered necessary are specifically related to:

- Need to **simplify and standardize online application procedures**: to make the application process easier, following reports from students, significant changes have been made to the site and a single, uniform application form has been created for UNICORE 6.0. In 2024, the implementation of a new digital platform was initiated, introducing key features aimed at enhancing the efficiency and transparency of the process, including: individual registration for students, universities, and UNHCR offices; a simplified and accessible online application system; timely refugee status verification by UNHCR field Offices; management of the selection process by universities; verification of personal data and pre-departure arrangements by UNHCR Offices abroad; and regular access to data and monitoring by the UNHCR Office in Italy;
- **Student support in pre-registration, visa application and issuance procedures**. Students reported difficulties in obtaining the Declaration of Value (DoV) required by some universities for access and matriculation to the master's degree Program. A further critical issue was found in the acquisition of a declaration of indigence from the Italian authority in order to access the facilities offered by the Universities;
- Streamline **travel document issuance operations**. Delays have been experienced in the issuance of travel documents by the authority of jurisdiction in the country of first asylum; in some cases, it was necessary to resort - exceptionally - to the issuance of *laissez-passer*. To ensure that refugees can finalize visa-related procedures in the time strictly necessary, the criteria for the selection of countries of departure will continue to include the requirement that travel documents are actually available for refugees. Where students



have arrived in Italy on a *laissez-passer* basis or where it is not possible to renew the travel document issued abroad, appropriate arrangements will continue to be made with the Department of Public Security in order to consider the possible issuance of a Travel Document for Foreigners referred to in MAECI Circulars No. 48 of October 31, 1961 and Ministry of the Interior No. 300 of 24/02/2003, as has already occurred for some cases in the past;

- **Financial sustainability of the project.** The financial effort on the part of universities and local communities is considerable to support students on their path to inclusion. It is intended to expand and structure further local partnerships to broaden the involvement of local stakeholders, raise more awareness among the university community also in order to identify *fundraising* opportunities, and propose the ad hoc use of AMIF funds for the program in the future.

December 2024



VIDEO MATERIAL

Video Weldegabriel ITA: <https://youtu.be/JxCDi1-OpJk>

Video Weldegabriel ENG: <https://youtu.be/hGu8uuMJLd4>

Infografica ITA: <https://youtu.be/1ETd20D0upM>

Infografica ENG: <https://youtu.be/twCuotin4jw>

Video Saber ITA: https://youtu.be/wQ_pHtKW05s

Video Saber ENG: <https://youtu.be/CSfyLdUw0i0>

Video Yohannes ITA: <https://youtu.be/cPRWw5SiYBQ>

Video Yohannes ENG: <https://youtu.be/INri937Rn5w>

Video Divine: <https://youtu.be/k0f0UJI38BM>

WEBSITES

[UNICORE website](#)

[EU PASSWORLD](#)